

ANTHROPOLOGY + DESIGN

Anthropological Methods in the Field of Design at Technology Companies:

An Ethnographic Study of Non-Anthropologists and Trained Anthropologists Incorporated into the Design Process

Jonathan Calzada

Abstract

As the role of anthropology in the 21st century expands, product design companies are increasingly employing anthropological methodologies in an attempt to innovate new products and improve their consumers' experiences (Forsman and Rojas 2011; Kelly and Matthews 2014). However, these experiences are influenced by a system of interconnected relationships created around a product that can be subtle and complex subsequently necessitating an inquiry beyond the immediacy of the user-product relationship (Kelly 2014). This project seeks to compare the applications of anthropological methods employed by both anthropologists and non-anthropologists to the conventional use of such methods by anthropologists working on more traditional topics.



Background

Anthropologists and anthropological research methods have become increasingly vital to the design process of high-tech products over the last two decades (Forsman and Rojas 2011). These methods are so highly valued that many design firms and technology companies consider them a competitive advantage and a contributing factor in product innovation (Wasson 2000:382).

Intro

My interest lies in the role and value of anthropological (mainly ethnographic) methods in corporate environments within the field of design used by both non-anthropologists and trained anthropologists. We have data and literature that show us that this is often a different form of ethnography because it is unique to its environment, which is fluid and fast-paced (Forsman and Rojas 2011; Smith 2011; Malefyt 2009). I am going to show how anthropologists and non-anthropologists negotiate through dialogue in order to adapt their methods within their corporate situational context and as a result how they are evolving.

Methods

The methodology used for the proposed research will include participant-observation, one-on-one semi-structured interviews, and open-ended interviews with product designers, engineers, managers, researchers, and key individuals involved in research concerning the 'user-experience' of their product(s).

Anticipated Outcomes

In addition to obtaining data on how anthropological methods are being employed and adapt to business pressures, I expect to have the opportunity to look into the pedagogic aspects of non-anthropological training. This research will help to determine where interdisciplinary training is happening, what the content is, what their initial academic background was, and how methods are being employed. In short, I expect to find out what training subjects believe a person in their position needs in order to be competent in their practice.

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